Before the
FEDERAL COMMUNICATIONS COMMISSION
Washington, D.C. 20554

In the Matter of	)	
	)	
Reforming the High-Cost Program for an All-IP Future	)	WC Docket No. 26-96
	)	
Connect America Fund: A National Broadband Plan for Our Future High-Cost Universal Support	)	WC Docket No. 10-90

COMMENTS OF TAIWO FAUSIYAT ADESIYAN

I. INTRODUCTION AND SUMMARY

I respectfully submit these comments on the Notice of Proposed Rulemaking in the above-captioned proceedings.[1] I am a doctoral candidate in economics at Middle Tennessee State University, where my research concerns the economics of regulation and markets that serve small and rural enterprises.[2] I submit these comments as a written ex parte presentation in this permit-but-disclose proceeding.[3]

The NPRM proposes to reduce or redirect high-cost support where an unsubsidized competitor already serves a location. I support that goal. Support should not pay for networks that the market already provides. But the determination that a competitor is present is the hinge of the entire reform, and it rests on two things the NPRM leaves open: what counts as a competitor's service, and which version of the mapping data is used to find it. I make two recommendations:

1. **Add a price screen.** A competitor should count as serving a location only if a qualifying plan's total monthly cost, including amortized equipment and mandatory fees, is at or below the Commission's own reasonable comparability benchmark for that speed tier.
2. **Treat the Broadband Data Collection as a versioned register.** Each support determination should be pinned to a named data release, published and archived at the location level, reconciled against published totals, and required to persist across two

[1]Reforming the High-Cost Program for an All-IP Future; Connect America Fund: A National Broadband Plan for Our Future High-Cost Universal Support, WC Docket Nos. 26-96 and 10-90, Notice of Proposed Rulemaking, FCC 26-35 (adopted May 20, 2026; released May 21, 2026); 91 Fed. Reg. 34201 (June 5, 2026) (NPRM).

[2]These comments are filed in my individual capacity. The views expressed are my own and do not represent the views of Middle Tennessee State University.

[3]47 CFR §§ 1.1200(a), 1.1206(b); NPRM ¶ 57 (designating this proceeding permit-but-disclose).

semiannual collections before support is reduced, with reductions phased in and restored symmetrically if coverage disappears.

II. A COMPETITOR SHOULD COUNT ONLY IF ITS SERVICE IS AVAILABLE AT A REASONABLY COMPARABLE RATE

Section 254(b)(3) directs that consumers in rural and high-cost areas have access to services that are reasonably comparable to those in urban areas "and that are available at rates that are reasonably comparable to rates charged for similar services in urban areas."[4] Availability and price are two halves of a single statutory standard. The NPRM itself recognizes the gap: mapping data "does not include pricing information such as connection costs and recurring charges," while high-cost support has historically served to preserve reasonable comparability and affordability of rates.[5]

A location map that records only whether service can be ordered will therefore count as "served" a location where the only offering costs far more than the urban rate. Removing support from that location does not move it from subsidized service to competitive service. It may move it from affordable service to service that most households will not buy. The Commission already has the instrument needed to close this gap. Each year the Urban Rate Survey produces a reasonable comparability benchmark, and support recipients certify against it. For 2026, the benchmark for 100/20 Mbps service is $96.46 per month.[6]

I recommend that the Commission define a qualifying competitive offering as one that meets all of the following:

1. It meets the speed, latency, and usage thresholds the Commission adopts for the support mechanism at issue.
2. Its total monthly cost is at or below the current reasonable comparability benchmark for the corresponding speed and usage tier. Total monthly cost should include the recurring service charge, every mandatory fee, and required equipment and installation charges amortized over a stated period (for example, 24 months).
3. It is available to new residential customers as a standalone service, not only as part of a bundle or a time-limited promotion.

[4] 47 U.S.C. § 254(b)(3).

[5] NPRM ¶ 38.

[6] Wireline Competition Bureau and Office of Economics and Analytics Announce Results of 2026 Urban Rate Survey for Fixed Voice and Broadband Services, DA 25-1088 (WCB/OEA Dec. 19, 2025) (2026 URS Public Notice) (reporting a benchmark of $96.46 for 100/20 Mbps service, for both the 800 GB and unlimited usage tiers, in areas outside Alaska).

A price screen of this kind is technology-neutral. It applies the same test to fixed wireless, cable, fiber, and satellite. This matters for the NPRM's questions about low-earth-orbit satellite service.[7] Where satellite service carries substantial up-front equipment charges, amortizing those charges into the monthly cost lets the Commission compare it to terrestrial service on equal terms. That comparison will favor some satellite offerings and disfavor others. The screen does not decide which in advance.

The screen also places little new burden on providers. The benchmark already exists and is updated every year. Competitors need to report only the price of their lowest-cost qualifying plan, or the Commission can collect it as a narrow, certified supplement when a competitor's presence is the basis for reducing another carrier's support.

III. THE BROADBAND DATA COLLECTION SHOULD BE TREATED AS A VERSIONED REGISTER

The NPRM asks how the "snapshot" nature of mapping data should factor into support decisions that run for multiple years,[8] and what opportunity support recipients should have to dispute coverage claims.[9] Both questions point to the same issue. The Broadband Data Collection is a register kept in the present tense. It is updated as filings, challenges, and corrections are processed. A support determination, by contrast, is a decision about money at a fixed point in time. If the determination does not record exactly which version of the register it relied on, the decision cannot later be reproduced, audited, or fairly challenged.

A. Evidence from another federal register

My own work shows how a current-state government register can return incomplete data with no visible sign that anything is missing. Through the Farm Share Evidence Program, I archive the USDA Local Food Directories each month. In September 2026, I compared two official ways of retrieving the same register on the same day: the bulk download and the public API queried state by state. The bulk download matched USDA's published totals exactly. The state-by-state API sweep returned between 30 and 80 percent of the listings, depending on the directory (for example, 1,401 of 4,692 on-farm markets and 753 of 2,002 community supported agriculture listings). It reported no error.[10]

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[7] NPRM ¶¶ 41–43.

[8] NPRM ¶ 39.

[9] NPRM ¶ 40.

[10] T. F. Adesiyan, The Farm Share Evidence Program (Version v0.1.0) [Computer software], Zenodo (2026), https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22834814. Counts are from the September 2026 capture of the USDA Local Food Directories (27,891 listings across five directories). The bulk download matched USDA's published directory totals exactly.

I do not offer this as evidence about the Broadband Data Collection, which is a different system maintained by a different agency. I offer it to show the failure mode. When a register is reached through one route and not checked against its published totals, a silent gap can look like a true absence. In the high-cost context, a silent gap in coverage data would look like a competitor that is not there, or one that is. Either error moves support to the wrong place. The safeguards below are designed so that such an error would be visible and correctable.

B. Recommended safeguards

1. **Pin each determination to a named release.** Every support decision should cite the specific Broadband Data Collection release and as-of date on which it relied.
2. **Publish and archive the location-level file.** The Commission should publish, for each affected study area, the location-level list of locations deemed served and the competitor relied on, and keep that file permanently available, so that the decision can be reproduced later.
3. **Reconcile against published totals.** Before relying on a determination, the Commission or the administrator should confirm that location counts in the determination file reconcile with the totals published for the same release.
4. **Require persistence.** A location should be treated as competitively served only if the qualifying service appears in two consecutive semiannual collections. This filters out transient entries and gives the challenge process time to work.
5. **Phase reductions.** Consistent with the NPRM's proposed transition path, support should be reduced in steps over several years rather than all at once.[11]
6. **Restore support symmetrically.** If a competitor exits, or a later release shows the location is no longer served by a qualifying offering, support eligibility should be restored by the same rules that removed it.

Each safeguard is inexpensive relative to the support at stake, and together they turn a disputed snapshot into an auditable record. They also give support recipients and competitors a fixed object to challenge, which makes the challenge process the NPRM contemplates more useful.

IV. WHY THIS MATTERS FOR RURAL ENTERPRISES

The USDA directories I archive list tens of thousands of small farm enterprises—on-farm markets, community supported agriculture operations, agritourism businesses, and food hubs—that depend on internet access to take orders, list products, and reach customers. Many operate in rural areas. I offer these listings to illustrate the kinds of enterprises at stake, not as an estimate of how many are

[11] NPRM ¶ 23 (seeking comment on a multi-year transition with year-by-year percentage reductions in support).

located in the study areas the NPRM's proposals would affect. For enterprises of this kind, the difference between affordable service and merely available service is the difference between selling online and not.

V. CONCLUSION

I support the Commission's goal of directing high-cost support away from locations that an unsubsidized competitor already serves. To make that determination accurate and fair, the Commission should (1) count a competitor only when its qualifying service is available at or below the reasonable comparability benchmark, and (2) treat the Broadband Data Collection as a versioned register, with determinations pinned to named releases, published and archived, reconciled, persistent across two collections, phased, and symmetric. I appreciate the opportunity to comment.

Respectfully submitted,

/s/ Taiwo Fausiyat Adesiyan
Taiwo Fausiyat Adesiyan
Doctoral Candidate, Department of Economics and Finance
Middle Tennessee State University, Murfreesboro, Tennessee, USA
ORCID: 0000-0002-2023-3624
adesiyanfausiyat010@gmail.com

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